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■ The Artemis II crewed lunar mission lifts off from Pad 39B at Kennedy Space Centre in Cape Canaveral, Florida, on Wednesday.

Artemis II: Mission that could change how we see Earth

First crewed lunar mission in 50 years to unlock new views of Moon — and our planet

DUBAI
BY JAY HILOTIN
Senior Assistant Editor

Humans are heading back to the Moon — and this time, what astronauts see could reshape how we understand not just the lunar surface, but Earth itself.

Nasa's Artemis II lifted off late Wednesday aboard the Space Launch System rocket, sending four astronauts on a 10-day journey around the Moon — the first crewed mission to its vicinity in over 50 years.

The mission carries astronauts Reid Wiseman, Victor Glover, Christina Koch and Jeremy Hansen aboard the Orion

spacecraft, marking humanity's return to deep space since the Apollo era.

Unlike Apollo missions, which focused on the Moon's near side, Artemis II will take astronauts around the far side — a region never seen directly by human eyes.

Scientists say this could offer fresh insights into why the Moon's near and far sides differ so dramatically, and how it evolved over billions of years.

"The Moon is like an extension of Earth," said Noah Petro of Nasa "When we study it, we're also learning about our own planet."

Why this mission matters

Apollo missions between 1968 and 1972 transformed our understanding of the Moon, bringing back samples that revealed it once had a global magma ocean and likely formed after a massive collision with Earth.

But those missions explored only a limited region. Artemis aims to go further — eventually targeting the lunar poles and other unexplored areas to uncover:

- How much water exists on the Moon
- Why its surface varies so widely
- How it connects to Earth's early history.

While Artemis II is a major technical milestone — testing Nasa's next-generation rocket and spacecraft — scientists say its real value lies in discovery.

Astronauts will travel farther than any humans in history, reaching about 250,000 miles from Earth during the flyby.

And with future missions planned to land on the lunar surface, the programme could usher in a new era of exploration — with implications stretching beyond the Moon to future missions to Mars.

TRUMP THREATENS TO BOMB IRAN BACK TO 'STONE AGE'

Tehran vows 'crushing' response as conflict widens

DUBAI
BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

US President Donald Trump has escalated his rhetoric against Iran, warning he would bomb the country "back to the stone ages," prompting Tehran to vow a "crushing" response as the conflict showed signs of widening across the region.

Minutes after Trump's threat, US Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth reinforced the message, posting: "Back to the Stone Age."

"Over the next two to three weeks, we are going to bring them back to the Stone Ages, where they belong," Trump said in an address to the nation on Wednesday, adding that US forces would meet their battlefield goals "very, very shortly."

Iran defiant

Iran responded sharply. The military's operational command, Khatam Al Anbiya, said the war would continue until the United States faced "humiliation, disgrace... and surrender," according to state television. Spokesman Ebrahim Zolfagari said US and Israeli assessments of Iran's military strength were "incomplete."

The United States and Israel have stepped up strikes, hitting a century-old medical research centre in Tehran, a bridge near the capital and steel plants, signalling a widening target set. Iran's two largest steel plants have been forced out of action after multiple waves of attacks, the companies said.

Trump said the US was close to achieving its core military objectives and described Iran

MOHAMED, TRUMP DISCUSS REGIONAL DEVELOPMENTS

President His Highness Sheikh Mohamed Bin Zayed Al Nahyan held a phone call with Donald Trump, President of the United States of America, on Wednesday during which they discussed developments in the region and their serious implications for regional and international peace and security, as well as their impact on maritime security and the global economy.

The two sides also discussed the continued Iranian terrorist aggression targeting the UAE and other countries in the region, including attacks on civilians and civilian infrastructure, noting that it constitutes a violation of sovereignty and international law and undermines regional security and stability.

—WAM

as "essentially decimated," but offered no clear timeline for ending the war, while signalling the possibility of further escalation. Iran has rejected those claims, vowing to continue fighting.

Meanwhile, the UAE said its air defences intercepted 19 ballistic missiles and 26 drones launched from Iran, adding that since the conflict began, 457 ballistic missiles, 19 cruise missiles and more than 2,000 drones have been engaged.

Authorities in Abu Dhabi also responded to an incident near the Khalifa Economic

Zones (KEZAD), where debris from an intercepted missile caused minor damage but no injuries.

UAE Presidential adviser Dr Anwar Gargash said Iran had turned its Gulf coastline from a historic zone of coexistence into a base for regional aggression, contrasting it with the UAE's model of tolerance.

In Israel, multiple blasts were heard in Jerusalem as sirens sounded following incoming Iranian missile launches.

The Strait of Hormuz — a critical global energy artery — remains effectively closed, driving up oil and gas prices and disrupting global supply chains.

Macron blasts Trump

"You have to be serious. When you want to be serious, you don't say the opposite every day of what you said the day before. And perhaps you shouldn't talk every day," French President Emmanuel Macron said.

UN chief Antonio Guterres warned the conflict risks spiralling into a wider war. "We are on the edge of a wider war that would engulf the Middle East with dramatic impacts around the globe," he said.

French President Emmanuel Macron called a military operation to reopen Hormuz "unrealistic" and criticised Trump's shifting messaging.

Russia said it would seek a ceasefire to evacuate personnel from Iran's Bushehr nuclear plant, underscoring mounting international concern.

The GCC and Bahrain also condemned Iranian attacks on civilian infrastructure, warning they threaten regional stability and global energy markets.

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Dubai govt entities to integrate services into unified platform

Emirate enters new era managed autonomously through data and AI

DUBAI

In a landmark step in Dubai's digital transformation journey, Sheikh Hamdan bin Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Crown Prince of Dubai, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister of Defence of the UAE, and Chairman of The Executive Council of Dubai, announced that the emirate has entered a new era in which the city is managed autonomously through data and artificial intelligence, where integrated systems and unified data work intelligently to create a more seamless, proactive, and secure living experience.

His remarks came during his visit to Digital Dubai, where he affirmed that the initiatives led

The projects leverage technologies to simplify people's lives and enhance happiness.

by Digital Dubai in partnership with government entities represent not only technological transformation but also a strategic investment in the future, reinforcing Dubai's position as a global model for quality of life and a city defined by a constant sense of safety and reassurance.

Pioneering projects

During the visit, he reviewed progress across the overarching strategic digital transformation agenda overseen by Digital Dubai, the entity enabling this transformation, supported by

its two affiliated entities: the Digital Dubai Government Establishment and the Dubai Data and Statistics Establishment.

As part of the visit, he launched a number of pioneering strategic projects that mark a significant milestone in the journey towards a fully integrated digital city. The projects leverage technologies to simplify people's lives and enhance happiness. Commending the efforts of the teams, he said: "Digital Dubai's work with government entities is an investment in the future, reinforcing Dubai's leadership in safety and quality of life."

Sheikh Hamdan directed all Dubai government entities to integrate services for individuals and businesses into a unified digital ecosystem within one year. These services will be delivered through streamlined, specialised platforms that reduce time and effort.

—WAM
SEE ALSO P7

Second white rhino born at Dubai Safari Park

A milestone for park's breeding programme

DUBAI
BY ZAINAB HUSAIN
Features Writer

In a time of uncertainty across the region, a moment of hope emerged at Dubai's largest wildlife park with the birth of a second white rhino calf. The endangered species saw a healthy male born to mother Olive, later named Salam, the Arabic word for peace.

Muna Alhajeri, Director of Dubai Safari Park, described the birth as a milestone shared not only with the park's staff, but with conservation advocates worldwide.

With an estimated 15,700 white rhinos remaining in the wild and numbers continuing to decline, each birth within a managed breeding programme carries considerable weight. Salam weighed



73.5 kg at birth and has since been progressing well, already standing, walking, and suckling under the attentive care of the park's zoological team.

Salam is the second white rhino born under the park's endangered species breeding programme, following Onyx in 2024. The programme focuses on bolstering vulnerable populations through partnerships with wildlife institutions locally and internationally.